

The King's Seal and the Storm at Frostmere

Knight's story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1

Sir Elowen Brightsteel heard the bell before she heard the shouting.

It came from the highest tower of Sunward Keep, a single iron note that rolled across the courtyards like thunder trapped in a horn. Pages ran with ink on their fingers. Stable boys skidded in the straw. Even the geese stopped arguing.

Elowen straightened from where she was helping a squire tighten a saddle strap. Her armor was scuffed from practice, her braid was coming loose, and her smile looked much too cheerful for a day that began with alarm.

“Again?” groaned Jory the squire, glancing up. “It’s always again.”

“Elbows up, chin up,” Elowen said, giving the saddle strap a final tug. “If it’s trouble, we meet it politely and then refuse to lose.”

Jory snorted. “That’s not a real plan.”

“It’s the beginning of one.”

A messenger burst through the yard gates, horse foaming, cloak ripped as if the road itself had tried to keep him. He didn’t dismount so much as fall off in front of the steward. His boots hit the stones with a crack.

“From Frostmere,” he wheezed. “From Lady Maris of the northern marches.”

The steward took the parchment as if it were hot coal. His eyes moved fast over the lines. Then his face turned the color of weak porridge.

“The river gates,” he said quietly. “The agreement...”

Elowen stepped closer. “Sir? What agreement?”

The steward swallowed. “Frostmere’s dam is failing. If it breaks, it will flood the lower villages and—worse—wash away the old border markers. The lords on both sides will argue whose land is whose. And when lords argue, swords start making speeches.”

Jory’s mouth fell open. “A war over mud?”

“Over pride,” Elowen corrected.

The steward held up the parchment. “Lady Maris begs Sunward Keep to send help and to seal this letter with the King’s signet—today. The King’s council won’t act without proof. Without a sealed letter, no engineers, no timber, no labor, no supplies.”

Elowen’s eyes flicked to the tower where the King’s seal was kept under lock and oath. “Then we seal it.”

The steward’s voice dropped. “The signet is in the Shrine of Oaths. Only a sworn knight may carry it. Only one who understands what a seal means.”

Elowen lifted her chin. “Then choose me.”

There was a short silence, like a sword pausing halfway from its sheath.

“You are young,” someone muttered.

Elowen grinned. “So is the dam, if it’s about to fall.”

The steward looked as if he wanted to argue, but urgency pushed him forward. “Very well. Sir Elowen Brightsteel, by the oath of your spurs, you will take Lady Maris’s letter, carry the King’s signet, and seal the message before sunset at Frostmere. If you fail, the north floods and the border burns.”

Jory grabbed her arm. “You can’t do this alone!”

Elowen patted his hand. “Who said I was alone?”

From the shadows by the stables came a small cough. A girl stepped out, all freckles and clever eyes, carrying a leather satchel stuffed with tools that clinked softly.

“I’m Sella,” she said. “Apprentice to Master Brann the seal-cutter. I know wax, metal, and what happens when you press too hard.” She lifted her chin in a mirror of Elowen’s. “And I run faster than most horses, but don’t tell the horses.”

Jory pointed at himself. “And I’m—”

“A brave squire who will not faint at the sight of mud,” Elowen said before he could protest. “Saddle my mare. Pack rope, oilcloth, and food. We ride.”

As they hurried, the messenger croaked, “The road to Frostmere is blocked. Storms. Fallen trees. And there are... men watching. Men who want the dam to break.”

Elowen’s smile thinned into something sharper. “Then we’ll have to be quicker than rain and wiser than greedy men.”

She took the unsealed letter, slipped it into her breastplate where it would be safe, and ran toward the Shrine of Oaths. Every step echoed one thought: A seal is not just wax. It is responsibility made visible.

Chapter 2

The Shrine of Oaths smelled of old stone and new promises.

A single lantern burned before a carved altar. On it sat the signet case—iron-bound oak with a lock that looked like it had bitten thieves in the past.

The knight-warden, Sir Garron, stood guard. His beard was gray, his eyes sharp enough to shave with. When Elowen approached, he lifted a hand.

“State your purpose, Sir Elowen.”

“To borrow the King’s signet,” she said, “and return it untouched. I must seal an urgent letter to prevent flood and war.”

Sir Garron studied her face as if it were a map. “Words are easy. Seals are not. Do you know what the King’s mark means?”

Elowen nodded once. “It means the King binds himself to act. It means the receiver must listen. It means if I misuse it, I stain more than wax—I stain trust.”

Sella, standing behind, whispered, “Also it means I get to see the signet up close, which is—”

Elowen cleared her throat.

Sir Garron’s mouth twitched, the smallest hint of amusement. “You speak well. Now swear.”

Elowen knelt, gauntlet to heart. “By my honor, by the steel I wear, by the people who sleep under this roof, I will seal only the true letter, for the true need, and bring the signet home.”

The warden unlocked the case. Inside lay the signet ring—heavy gold set with a carved sunburst. The grooves looked like tiny valleys where wax would flow and harden into proof.

Elowen took it carefully, as if it might crack. It didn’t. It weighed more than she expected.

“Responsibility usually does,” Sir Garron murmured.

Outside, her mare, Lark, stamped impatiently. Jory had packed the saddlebags so full they looked like they'd swallowed a bakery.

"We're ready," Jory said, though his voice squeaked slightly. "Mostly."

Sella hopped up behind Jory on a sturdy pony named Pebble. "If anyone asks, Pebble and I are on a quiet shopping trip," she announced. "For very urgent... turnips."

Elowen swung into the saddle. Wind tugged at her cloak like a friend trying to hurry her along.

The gate captain called, "Storm clouds to the north. Ride smart!"

Elowen saluted with two fingers. "I plan to."

They rode out, hooves drumming the road, Sunward Keep shrinking behind them into a patch of stone and banner. The countryside opened into wet fields and twisting hedgerows. Far ahead, the northern sky was bruised purple with storm.

As they crossed the first bridge, Elowen felt the signet ring in her pouch and the unsealed letter against her chest. Two small things. Two heavy things.

Jory leaned forward. "So, what's the plan besides 'refuse to lose'?"

Elowen pointed with her chin at the road. "Step one: reach Frostmere before sunset. Step two: keep the signet safe. Step three: don't let anyone else decide our story."

Sella grinned. "Step four: if we meet villains, make them feel silly."

"Only if there's time," Elowen said, and urged Lark faster.

Chapter 3

By midday the storm caught them.

Rain fell in slanted sheets, turning the road into a slippery ribbon. The trees on either side groaned as the wind pushed their crowns together like arguing giants.

At a bend, they found the first problem: a huge oak lay across the road, roots ripped up, mud dangling from them like torn cloth. Water rushed around its trunk.

Jory stared. "We can't jump that."

"Not unless Lark grows wings," Elowen said. She dismounted, boots sinking. "We go around."

Sella peered into the woods. "Around looks like 'get lost and become a legend' territory."

Elowen ran a hand along the oak. "We don't have time for wandering. Rope."

Jory pulled out the coil. Elowen looped it around the trunk and tied it to Lark's saddle. She checked the knot twice, then once more, because a good knot is a small kind of courage.

"Stand clear," she said.

Lark leaned into the harness, muscles bunching. The rope went taut with a twang that sounded like a snapped string on a harp. The trunk shifted an inch.

Jory's eyes widened. "It moved!"

"It's polite," Sella said. "It's making room."

Elowen clicked her tongue. "Again, Lark!"

The mare strained, hooves digging. The oak groaned and rolled, slowly, like an enormous reluctant barrel. Mud slid and splashed. With a final heave, the trunk moved just enough to open a narrow path by the ditch.

Jory whooped. Immediately, he slipped in the mud and landed on his backside with a wet thump.

Sella laughed, not meanly. "A heroic fall! Very authentic."

Jory, dripping, pointed at Elowen. "You did that with a horse and a rope."

"With a horse, a rope, and two friends who didn't panic," Elowen said. "Now, through."

They squeezed past. The ditch tried to steal a boot, but Elowen hauled Jory free by his collar.

Further on, the rain eased. The road rose into a stretch of heath where rocks poked through the grass like old teeth. There, they saw the second problem.

Three riders waited ahead, cloaks dark, horses restless. One held a spear across the road like a bar.

Elowen slowed, keeping her posture calm. Her hand hovered near her sword but did not draw it. A knight's strength was not only in striking—it was in choosing when not to.

The lead rider raised his visor just enough to show a grin. "Travelers. Dangerous day for travel."

"We have urgent business," Elowen said. "Let us pass."

"Urgent," the rider echoed, tasting the word. "Is it urgent enough to pay a toll?"

Jory muttered, "We don't have toll money. We have... turnips." He glanced at

Sella.

Sella whispered back, “We have no turnips.”

Elowen kept her voice steady. “This is the King’s road. There is no toll.”

The rider tapped his spear. “There is today.”

Elowen studied them. Their horses were well-fed, their boots were too clean for men who lived by honest work, and the crest on the lead rider’s glove was half-scraped away. Not knights. Not soldiers. Men hiding.

“Who sent you?” she asked.

The rider’s grin widened. “A friend who dislikes the northern lady. A friend who thinks a broken dam makes certain... bargains easier.”

Sella’s eyes narrowed. “So you’re hoping for a flood.”

“Floods wash away problems,” the rider said. “And create new opportunities.”

Elowen inhaled, slow. She could draw her sword and try her luck. Three against one, plus two companions—bad odds, and the road was slick.

Instead she smiled, bright as morning. “Of course. A toll. How foolish of me.”

Jory stared at her like she’d grown a second helmet.

Elowen reached into her pouch and pulled out the signet case—not opening it, simply letting its iron and oak show. “We carry something of value,” she said. “But it’s delicate. We must protect it from rain.”

The riders leaned forward slightly, greedy curiosity waking.

“Hand it over,” the lead rider said.

Elowen's smile didn't change. "Not here. Too wet. If water damages it, it's worthless. There's an old shepherd's hut just beyond the heath—dry roof, solid floor. Let us step inside. I'll show you."

Sella caught on quickly. "Yes! Dry floor. Wax hates wet floors. Everyone knows that."

The lead rider hesitated. "No tricks."

"A knight's word," Elowen said smoothly, leaving out the part where she was not promising what he thought.

They rode together toward the hut, a low stone shelter crouched behind a hill. Inside, the air smelled of sheep and smoke from long ago. The roof leaked only a little.

Elowen dismounted first. "I'll fetch it," she said, and stepped in with the case.

As the riders crowded the doorway, she flicked her eyes to Sella.

Now, she mouthed.

Sella slipped behind them like a shadow with freckles. Pebble's saddlebags clinked softly. She drew out a small tin and, with a quick twist, popped it open.

Grease.

Sella smeared it across the threshold stones—one swift, silent sweep.

Elowen held up the case. "Here," she said, drawing their attention. "Closer."

The lead rider stepped in, boot sliding an inch. He frowned, shifting weight.

Elowen's voice rang clear. "Jory!"

Jory, outside, slapped Lark's rump. The mare lunged forward, bumping the lead rider's horse, which jerked sideways. The rider tried to steady himself, but his boot hit the greased stone.

He yelped, arms windmilling, and went down with a crash that shook dust from the rafters. His spear clattered away.

For a heartbeat, everyone stared.

Sella said politely, "Oops."

Elowen moved fast—she kicked the fallen spear farther in, slammed the hut door against the second rider, and shoved a wooden beam into place.

"Hey!" came muffled shouting.

"Come out!" another voice roared.

Elowen leaned her shoulder against the door. "They'll break it."

"Not if we leave first," Sella said, already swinging into her pony's saddle.

Elowen dashed out the back—there was no proper back door, just a missing stone and a gap big enough for a determined knight. She vaulted through, landed in wet grass, and ran for Lark.

Jory was pale. "You just... trapped them."

"I gave them a lesson," Elowen said, mounting. "Greed makes you slippery."

They rode hard, the shouts fading behind them, swallowed by wind.

Jory let out a shaky laugh. "That was... that was clever."

Sella puffed her cheeks proudly. "My grease has saved many pies from sticking.

Today it saved a kingdom.”

Elowen glanced north. The clouds were thicker now, and in the far distance she imagined the dam, straining like a clenched fist.

“Keep moving,” she said. “The real race hasn’t even started.”

Chapter 4

By late afternoon they reached the edge of Frostmere’s lands, and the world changed.

The ground became darker, soaked and heavy. Streams that should have been gentle were swollen and loud. Water ran in places it had no right to be—across paths, through gardens, over stones that used to be dry.

In the nearest village, people hauled bundles uphill. Chickens squawked from baskets. A baker carried a sack of flour like it was a sleeping child.

An old woman pointed with a trembling hand. “The dam’s groaning. You can hear it at night. Like a giant with a toothache.”

Elowen rode to the village green, where Lady Maris’s banner hung limp in the rain. A captain of the watch approached, face tight.

“Knight of Sunward?” he asked.

Elowen raised her hand in salute. “Sir Elowen Brightsteel. I carry Lady Maris’s urgent letter. I must seal it and deliver it to the King’s council.”

The captain’s shoulders sagged in relief so strong it looked painful. “Thank the saints. Lady Maris is at the dam with the engineers, but they won’t start the full reinforcement without the King’s authority. They fear being accused of crossing

borders with tools and men.”

“Borders won’t matter if the valley is a lake,” Sella muttered.

The captain led them toward the river. The roar grew louder until it filled Elowen’s ribs. When they reached the dam, she saw why fear lived here.

It was an old stone wall holding back a wide, furious reservoir. Water spilled in thin streams through cracks, as if the dam were sweating. Men hammered wooden braces into place. Others dragged timber, their boots sinking into mud.

Lady Maris stood on a platform, cloak plastered to her shoulders, hair braided tight like a rope of determination. When she saw Elowen, she strode over, eyes bright with exhaustion.

“You came,” she said. “Sunward keeps its word.”

Elowen dismounted and bowed. “You asked for a seal. I brought the signet.”

Maris’s gaze flicked to the pouch. “Good. Because we have hours, not days. If this wall fails tonight—” She didn’t finish. She didn’t need to. The roaring water completed the sentence.

Elowen pulled out the letter, still unsealed, the parchment edges dry under her armor. “Where do we seal it?”

Maris’s mouth tightened. “There’s a problem. The seal wax we have is soaked. Our messenger wax is ruined. Without proper wax, the impression could blur. The King’s council might claim it’s forged.”

Sella stepped forward, opening her satchel. “I brought wax. Not the fancy kind—just honest beeswax and resin. And I brought a little stove pot. And two very stubborn matches.”

Jory blinked. “You carry matches?”

Sella shrugged. "Responsibility means planning. Also, I like fire. In a safe way."

They found a sheltered nook under a canvas awning. The wind snapped at the edges, trying to peek in. Sella set her small pot on a flat stone and shielded the flame with her hands. The wax began to melt, slow and golden.

Elowen took the signet ring out. Even in the dim light, the sunburst pattern seemed to glow with its own confidence.

Maris watched her. "You understand what this means?"

Elowen nodded. "If I press this into wax, I'm asking the King to act. I must be certain the letter is true."

Maris held Elowen's gaze. "It is. The dam is failing. Our border treaty depends on clear markers. If the river shifts, the lords of Eastmere will claim our fields. My cousin in Eastmere is proud enough to duel a tree if it leans toward him."

Jory murmured, "I once met a man like that. The tree won."

Elowen allowed a quick smile, then sobered. "Then we seal it. For the villages. For peace."

Sella tipped the melted wax onto the folded parchment. It pooled like a small, shining lake. Elowen positioned the signet carefully, hand steady despite the wind and the roar and the weight of what she was doing.

"Once," Sir Garron's voice echoed in her memory, "a seal is a promise you can't take back."

Elowen pressed.

The wax yielded, then resisted, then accepted the shape. She held for a heartbeat, counting silently, then lifted the ring.

A perfect sunburst stared up at them, crisp and undeniable.

Jory let out a breath he'd been holding. "It looks... official."

Sella nodded gravely. "It looks expensive."

Lady Maris's eyes shone. "It looks like help."

A runner took the sealed letter at once, tucking it into an oilcloth pouch. "I ride for the King's council," he said, and was gone in a spray of mud.

Elowen felt the sudden emptiness in her chest where the letter had been. The main task was done—but the dam still groaned, and the night still waited.

Maris turned back to the engineers. "Now we work," she called. "With the King's authority coming, we can request men from both sides. No more arguing. Only building."

Elowen stepped closer to the dam, listening. The stone vibrated faintly, like a drum under pressure.

"We should leave," Jory said. "Our mission—"

"Our mission was responsibility," Elowen replied. "That includes staying long enough to make sure the letter matters."

She rolled up her sleeves over her mail. "Where do you need hands?"

Maris's expression softened into fierce gratitude. "There. Those braces. If they slip, the crack widens."

Elowen went to work, shoulder to timber, boots in mud, courage measured not in grand speeches but in how long you can hold a beam steady while water tries to rewrite the world.

Chapter 5

Night arrived like a black cloak thrown over the valley.

Torches flared along the dam, their light trembling in the wind. The reservoir behind the wall pressed hard, a silent enemy with endless weight. Every so often, a stone shifted with a sound like a jaw grinding.

Elowen worked beside villagers and guards, her armor muddy, her hands aching. Jory hauled planks until his arms shook. Sella, surprisingly fearless, crawled under supports to wedge small stones and bits of wood where they could stop a wobble.

"Remind me," Jory panted, "to become a poet. Poets sit indoors."

Sella's voice echoed from under a brace. "Poets also starve."

"Fine," Jory said. "A poet with snacks."

A shout rose from the far end of the dam. "Crack widening!"

Elowen sprinted, boots splashing. She reached a section where water was seeping faster, a thin stream that had become a steady spill. The engineer in charge, Master Rulfe, pressed his ear to the stone like a doctor listening to a sick chest.

"It's giving," he said. "We need another brace across this face, but we're out of long beams."

Maris's jaw clenched. "The supply carts are stuck on the south road."

Elowen looked toward the dark hills. "There's a fallen oak on the King's road," she said. "We moved it earlier. Its trunk is huge."

Rulfe stared. "You want to cut it into beams? Tonight?"

Elowen's optimism sparked again, stubborn as flint. "If we don't, the river will cut the dam into pieces for us."

Maris turned to her captain. "Send men with axes. Bring that oak. If Sunward's knight says it can be done, we'll do it."

Jory gulped. "I said 'poet,' not 'lumberjack.'"

Elowen clapped his shoulder. "Congratulations. You've been promoted to 'useful.'"

They rode with a small team to where the oak still lay near the heath. Under torchlight, the trunk looked even larger, its bark slick with rain.

"Axes!" the captain ordered.

Metal rang against wood. Chips flew. The work was brutal and steady, a rhythm of effort. Elowen took her turn, her arms burning, breath coming out in foggy bursts.

Between swings, Sella said, "This is the strangest seal-making job I've ever had."

Elowen chuckled through grit teeth. "Seals lead to odd places."

When they had enough rough beams, they dragged them back on sleds of branches. The dam waited, patient and furious.

At the crack, Master Rulfe shouted instructions. "Angle it! No, not like you're poking a dragon—like you're hugging a wall!"

Elowen and Jory heaved the beam into place. The wood creaked, then settled. Men hammered stakes. Ropes tightened. For a moment, the leak slowed.

Elowen leaned close to the stone, listening. The grinding sound eased, just

slightly, like a clenched jaw relaxing.

Maris exhaled. "That buys us time."

"How much?" Elowen asked.

"Until dawn, perhaps," Rulfe said. "If the storm calms."

If. The smallest word, the heaviest.

As they worked, Elowen's mind kept circling back to the signet ring safe in her pouch. The seal was already made. The letter was on its way. But sealing a message didn't seal the future. People did that, with choices.

Near midnight, hoofbeats approached. A rider arrived from the south, lantern swinging.

"Message from Eastmere!" he called. "Lord Hadrik sends men and timber—under Lady Maris's authority, pending the King's seal. He says... he says he'd rather build than brawl."

Maris looked stunned. "Hadrik? He hates sharing air."

The rider shrugged. "He says the river doesn't care about pride."

Elowen felt a warmth spread in her chest, not from fire but from hope. "The sealed letter is already changing minds," she said.

Jory rubbed his sore arms. "Good. Because my arms have no more opinions."

They held the dam through the darkest hours. When the storm finally began to tire, the wind softened, and the rain turned from furious slap to gentle tapping.

At dawn, pale light slid over the water. The dam still stood.

A cheer rose—ragged, exhausted, real. Men hugged. Someone cried. Someone laughed so hard they nearly fell into the mud.

Elowen sat on a stone, muddy and smiling. Responsibility, she thought, was not glamorous. It was staying awake when you wanted sleep. It was doing the hard thing because others couldn't afford your comfort.

Sella nudged her boot with a toe. "You did it," she said.

"We did," Elowen corrected, and pulled the signet ring from her pouch to check it. It gleamed, unstained.

Maris approached, eyes red from tiredness but bright with pride. "When the King's council receives your sealed letter, they will send official engineers, and both sides will rebuild stronger. You may have stopped a war."

Elowen shook her head. "A seal helped. But the choice to help came from people."

Maris nodded slowly. "Then let us make a better choice permanent."

Chapter 6

Two days later, the valley looked different.

The storm had passed, leaving air that smelled of wet earth and fresh-cut wood. The dam was wrapped in new supports like a wounded knight bandaged for healing. Camps of workers dotted both banks—Frostmere and Eastmere together, sharing tools, sharing meals, sharing complaints about blisters.

On the hill above the dam, a long pole had been planted. Lady Maris stood beside it, and beside her stood Lord Hadrik of Eastmere—tall, proud, and now slightly humbled by nature's indifference. Between them was a folded piece of

cloth, still hidden.

Elowen stood with Jory and Sella among the crowd. Her armor was cleaned, though the dents remained—proof of effort, not damage. The signet ring rested once more in its iron-bound case, ready to return to Sunward Keep.

A herald read aloud a message bearing the King's seal—Elowen's seal, pressed by her hand but backed by the King's authority.

"By the Sunburst Mark," the herald proclaimed, "let the borders be set by agreement, not by flood. Let both marches rebuild the dam as one. Let the old stones be replaced by new markers set together, so no storm may turn neighbors into enemies."

Lord Hadrik cleared his throat. "Lady Maris," he said stiffly, "I have been... difficult."

Maris arched an eyebrow. "That is a gentle word for it."

A ripple of laughter rolled through the crowd.

Hadrik's lips twitched. "Yes. Well. The river has taught me that if I argue with every change, I will drown in my own stubbornness. I would rather raise a wall against water than against you."

Maris's expression softened. "Then let us raise something better than a wall."

Together, they unfurled the cloth and clipped it to the pole.

A banner snapped open in the wind: half Frostmere's silver heron, half Eastmere's red oak, stitched together down the middle with a bright golden sunburst—symbol of the King's promise and the shared work beneath it.

No war drums sounded. No swords were drawn. Only the steady hammering of builders and the murmur of relieved villagers.

Elowen felt her throat tighten. She hadn't expected a banner to feel like a victory, but it did—because it meant people had chosen responsibility over rage.

Jory nudged her. "So... that's the 'banner without war' you kept talking about?"

"I wasn't talking about it," Elowen said, amused. "But yes. Exactly that."

Sella squinted up at the stitching. "Nice sealwork in cloth form. Not my craft, but I approve."

Maris stepped toward Elowen. "Sir Elowen Brightsteel," she said loudly enough for those nearby to hear, "you carried urgency like a torch and did not drop it. You used courage, but also wit. And when the letter was sealed, you did not ride away from the consequences."

Elowen bowed, embarrassed by praise. "A seal is only useful if someone acts. You acted."

Maris smiled. "And you reminded others what a knight is for."

Hadrik, clearing his throat again, looked at Elowen. "If you ever need timber, do not... hesitate."

Jory whispered, "That's Eastmere for 'thank you.'"

Elowen laughed softly. "I'll remember."

That afternoon, Elowen rode back toward Sunward Keep with the signet safe and her companions close. The road still held mud, and her muscles still ached, but the air felt lighter.

As the keep's towers came into view, Jory asked, "Do you think we'll get another mission soon?"

Elowen's eyes sparkled. "Almost certainly."

Sella groaned. “Next time, can the urgent thing be sealing a letter about cake?”

Elowen considered, then nodded solemnly. “If cake prevents war, we will ride for cake.”

They rode under the flutter of distant banners, and the sun—real in the sky, not only in wax—broke through the clouds at last.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Why was Elowen asked to carry the King's signet to Frostmere?

- Because the signet was needed to authorize engineers and supplies to prevent a flood and possible war
- Because she wanted to show off her armor to Lady Maris
- Because the King ordered a parade through Frostmere
- Because she was the only rider available who knew the road

2) What clever trick did Elowen and Sella use to escape the men demanding a toll on the road?

- They greased the hut threshold so the men would slip and then closed the door to trap them
- Elowen challenged the leader to a duel and won, scaring the others away
- They paid the toll with the King's signet as proof of value
- They rode around the men using a hidden path Sella had mapped

3) What was the main reason the engineers at the dam needed the sealed letter from the King's council?

- They needed official authority so workers and materials from both sides could help without being accused of crossing borders
- They wanted the King to personally come and lead the repairs
- They needed a royal coin to buy extra timber from a far town
- They needed the signet to use as a tool for fixing the cracks

4) What role did the fallen oak trunk play in saving the dam?

- Its wood was cut into beams used as braces to support a widening crack in the dam
- It was pushed into the river to slow the current before the dam
- It was used to build a raft to move people to safety
- It was burned to signal for more help from nearby towns

5) How did sealing the letter with the King's signet actually influence Lord Hadrik of Eastmere?

- It persuaded him to send men and timber and to agree to rebuild the dam together, choosing cooperation over conflict
- It forced him to surrender part of his land to Lady Maris immediately
- It made him angry and he prepared to march to war
- It convinced him to build a new castle instead of helping with the dam

6) Which idea best describes Elowen's understanding of what a seal represents?

- A seal is a visible promise of responsibility that binds leaders to act and must be used honestly
- A seal is simply expensive decoration for important letters
- A seal is magic that can force people to obey without discussion
- A seal is a private treasure that should never leave the Shrine of Oaths

Correct answers:

1) Because the signet was needed to authorize engineers and supplies to prevent a flood and possible war
2) They greased the hut threshold so the men would slip and then closed the door to trap them 3) They needed official authority so workers and materials from both sides could help without being accused of crossing borders 4) Its wood was cut into beams used as braces to support a widening crack in the dam 5) It persuaded him to send men and timber and to agree to rebuild the dam together, choosing cooperation over conflict 6) A seal is a visible promise of responsibility that binds leaders to act and must be used honestly

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Steward: A person who manages supplies and tasks for a household or place.

Signet: A small metal stamp or ring used to leave a mark on wax.

Oath: A serious promise someone makes, often with a formal meaning.

Gauntlet: A heavy glove that knights wear to protect their hand in armor.

Warden: A guard or keeper in charge of a place or object.

Apprentice: A young person who learns a skill by working with an expert.

Engineers: People who design and build structures like bridges or dams.

Resin: A sticky, solid substance from trees used to make glue or seal wax.

Beeswax: Natural wax made by bees, used for candles or sealing letters.

Impression: The shape left in soft wax when a seal or stamp is pressed.

Forged: Made or copied to look real, often used about fake documents.

Braces: Strong supports put in place to hold something steady or safe.

Responsibility: A duty or job that someone must honestly care for and do.

Authority: The official power to give orders or make decisions.